ENGLISH C2 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Theme, rheme and information flow

Arrange clause openings and end-focus so given information anchors the message and new information receives appropriate prominence. The lesson connects form, meaning, register and real editorial decisions rather than treating the pattern as an isolated rule.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Use theme, rheme and information flow to guide the reader from an accessible point of departure to the most informative element while preserving the intended meaning and register.

Arrange clause openings and end-focus so given information anchors the message and new information receives appropriate prominence.

MODEL

What the inquiry ultimately exposed was a failure of institutional oversight.

theme/given frame + development + rheme/new focus

6 GUIDED STAGES · 30 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Recognise the main theme, rheme and information flow patterns in authentic contexts.

OUTCOME 2

02

Choose a form that accurately expresses guide the reader from an accessible point of departure to the most informative element.

OUTCOME 3

03

Avoid errors that change time, agency, emphasis or speaker commitment.

OUTCOME 4

04

Use the structure appropriately in high-level academic, professional and literary discourse.

Build meaning before form

Arrange clause openings and end-focus so given information anchors the message and new information receives appropriate prominence.

What theme, rheme and information flow communicates

Arrange clause openings and end-focus so given information anchors the message and new information receives appropriate prominence.

The central purpose is to guide the reader from an accessible point of departure to the most informative element. A successful choice therefore preserves the proposition while making the intended relationship, viewpoint or degree of commitment visible to the reader.

The revised model produced a markedly different result.	a familiar participant used as the point of departure
In the final dataset, a different pattern emerged.	a setting selected as the interpretive frame
What the inquiry ultimately exposed was a failure of institutional oversight.	the key new conclusion reserved for final position

How the pattern is built

Use this working formula: theme/given frame + development + rheme/new focus. The formula is a decision path: it identifies the trigger, the clause architecture and the element that carries tense or modality.

The model “What the inquiry ultimately exposed was a failure of institutional oversight.” shows the complete pattern in context. Rebuild the sentence from meaning to form instead of translating each word independently.

Choice	Structure	Example
Unmarked theme	subject/theme + predicate/new information	The revised model produced a markedly different result.
Marked theme	fronted frame + clause	In the final dataset, a different pattern emerged.
End focus	given frame + identifying clause + new focus	What the inquiry ultimately exposed was a failure of institutional oversight.

Choose by meaning, not by surface similarity

Neighbouring structures may contain similar words but perform different jobs. Compare the three reference patterns and name the intended effect before completing the sentence.

A reliable answer explains both why the chosen form works and why a plausible alternative would change the meaning, time relation, information focus or level of certainty.

Meaning	Best route
a familiar participant used as the point of departure	Unmarked theme
a setting selected as the interpretive frame	Marked theme
the key new conclusion reserved for final position	End focus

Register, discourse and editorial control

This grammar is especially useful in high-level academic, professional and literary discourse. Its value comes from helping the reader process a relationship efficiently, not from making the sentence sound artificially complex.

After editing, check recoverability, natural word order and consistency with the surrounding paragraph. If the marked structure creates ambiguity, return to a fuller or more neutral clause.

Reason through the pattern

The visual map moves from communicative purpose to structural trigger, then to the final clause. It keeps meaning and form visible at the same time so the learner can justify every choice.

01	02	03
theme/given frame	development	rheme/new focus

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Identify the communicative purpose before selecting a form: guide the reader from an accessible point of departure to the most informative element.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Locate the structural trigger and match it to one of the reference patterns.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Check time reference, clause relationships, agency and speaker commitment.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Read the complete sentence in context and confirm that its register suits high-level academic, professional and literary discourse.

STEP 5

Decision 5

Compare the result with a neutral alternative and keep the marked form only when it adds useful meaning.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Pattern	Form	Model
Unmarked theme	subject/theme + predicate/new information	The revised model produced a markedly different result.
Marked theme	fronted frame + clause	In the final dataset, a different pattern emerged.
End focus	given frame + identifying clause + new focus	What the inquiry ultimately exposed was a failure of institutional oversight.

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

The revised model produced a markedly different result.	a familiar participant used as the point of departure
In the final dataset, a different pattern emerged.	a setting selected as the interpretive frame
What the inquiry ultimately exposed was a failure of institutional oversight.	the key new conclusion reserved for final position

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not place unpredictable dense information in the theme without a discourse reason.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not front a frame that does not connect to the preceding discourse.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not bury the intended focus inside a long chain of postmodifiers.

Recognition in context

Choose the sentence whose grammar matches the stated communicative purpose.

A1 · MEANING DECISION 1

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a familiar participant used as the point of departure?

OPTIONS The revised model produced a markedly different result. · In the final dataset, a different pattern emerged. · What the inquiry ultimately exposed was a failure of institutional oversight.

A2 · MEANING DECISION 2

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a setting selected as the interpretive frame?

OPTIONS In the final dataset, a different pattern emerged. · What the inquiry ultimately exposed was a failure of institutional oversight. · The revised model produced a markedly different result.

A3 · MEANING DECISION 3

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: the key new conclusion reserved for final position?

OPTIONS What the inquiry ultimately exposed was a failure of institutional oversight. · The revised model produced a markedly different result. · In the final dataset, a different pattern emerged.

A4 · INTERPRETATION 4

What does “The revised model produced a markedly different result.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a familiar participant used as the point of departure · a setting selected as the interpretive frame · the key new conclusion reserved for final position

A5 · INTERPRETATION 5

What does “In the final dataset, a different pattern emerged.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a setting selected as the interpretive frame · the key new conclusion reserved for final position · a familiar participant used as the point of departure

A6 · INTERPRETATION 6

What does “What the inquiry ultimately exposed was a failure of institutional oversight.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS the key new conclusion reserved for final position · a familiar participant used as the point of departure · a setting selected as the interpretive frame

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Form and function

Identify both the structural family and the meaning carried by each model.

B1 · FORM AND FUNCTION 1

"The revised model produced a markedly different result." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Unmarked theme / Marked theme / End focus · Gap 2: a familiar participant used as the point of departure / a setting selected as the interpretive frame / the key new conclusion reserved for final position

B2 · FORM AND FUNCTION 2

"In the final dataset, a different pattern emerged." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Marked theme / End focus / Unmarked theme · Gap 2: a setting selected as the interpretive frame / the key new conclusion reserved for final position / a familiar participant used as the point of departure

B3 · FORM AND FUNCTION 3

"What the inquiry ultimately exposed was a failure of institutional oversight." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: End focus / Unmarked theme / Marked theme · Gap 2: the key new conclusion reserved for final position / a familiar participant used as the point of departure / a setting selected as the interpretive frame

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Guided discourse choices

Maintain accurate form and meaning across a connected sequence of decisions.

C1 · EDITORIAL PLANNING

Choose the model that expresses a familiar participant used as the point of departure: _____. Choose the model that expresses a setting selected as the interpretive frame: _____. Choose the model that expresses the key new conclusion reserved for final position: _____. Choose the model built with subject/theme + predicate/new information: _____. Choose the model built with fronted frame + clause: _____. Choose the model built with given frame + identifying clause + new focus: _____.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

In the final dataset, a different pattern emerged. · The revised model produced a markedly different result. · What the inquiry ultimately exposed was a failure of institutional oversight.

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

04 · PRACTICE STAGE

Open reconstruction

Recover the missing structural trigger without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT RECONSTRUCTION

_____ produced a markedly different result. _____, a different pattern emerged. What the inquiry ultimately exposed was _____. State the full structural pattern for Unmarked theme: _____. State the full structural pattern for Marked theme: _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled transformation

Rewrite the neutral source so that it performs the requested advanced function.

E1 · TRANSFORMATION 1

Rewrite “We already know the model; the new information is its result.” using the Unmarked theme pattern to express a familiar participant used as the point of departure.

_____
_____

E2 · TRANSFORMATION 2

Rewrite “A different pattern emerged in the final dataset.” using the Marked theme pattern to express a setting selected as the interpretive frame.

_____
_____

E3 · TRANSFORMATION 3

Rewrite “The inquiry exposed institutional failure.” using the End focus pattern to express the key new conclusion reserved for final position.

_____
_____

E4 · TRANSFORMATION 4

Rewrite “We already know the model; the new information is its result.” using the Unmarked theme pattern to express a familiar participant used as the point of departure.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative production

Use the grammar independently in realistic academic, professional and conversational contexts.

F1 · PRODUCTION TASK 1

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Unmarked theme to express a familiar participant used as the point of departure, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · PRODUCTION TASK 2

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Marked theme to express a setting selected as the interpretive frame, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · PRODUCTION TASK 3

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use End focus to express the key new conclusion reserved for final position, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: communicative purpose.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: structural trigger.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: meaning contrast.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: register choice.

_____
_____
_____

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

The revised model produced a markedly different result.

Unmarked theme is the best match because a familiar participant used as the point of departure.

A2

In the final dataset, a different pattern emerged.

Marked theme is the best match because a setting selected as the interpretive frame.

A3

What the inquiry ultimately exposed was a failure of institutional oversight.

End focus is the best match because the key new conclusion reserved for final position.

A4

a familiar participant used as the point of departure

The Unmarked theme pattern communicates a familiar participant used as the point of departure.

A5

a setting selected as the interpretive frame

The Marked theme pattern communicates a setting selected as the interpretive frame.

A6

the key new conclusion reserved for final position

The End focus pattern communicates the key new conclusion reserved for final position.

Form and function

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

Unmarked theme / a familiar participant used as the point of departure

The structure belongs to the Unmarked theme pattern. Its communicative purpose is a familiar participant used as the point of departure.

B2

Marked theme / a setting selected as the interpretive frame

The structure belongs to the Marked theme pattern. Its communicative purpose is a setting selected as the interpretive frame.

B3

End focus / the key new conclusion reserved for final position

The structure belongs to the End focus pattern. Its communicative purpose is the key new conclusion reserved for final position.

Guided discourse choices

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

The revised model produced a markedly different result.

Unmarked theme: subject/theme + predicate/new information.

C2

In the final dataset, a different pattern emerged.

Marked theme: fronted frame + clause.

C3

What the inquiry ultimately exposed was a failure of institutional oversight.

End focus: given frame + identifying clause + new focus.

C4

The revised model produced a markedly different result.

Unmarked theme: subject/theme + predicate/new information.

C5

In the final dataset, a different pattern emerged.

Marked theme: fronted frame + clause.

C6

What the inquiry ultimately exposed was a failure of institutional oversight.

End focus: given frame + identifying clause + new focus.

Open reconstruction

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

The revised model

Unmarked theme requires “The revised model” in this model. subject/theme + predicate/new information.

D2

In the final dataset

Marked theme requires “In the final dataset” in this model. fronted frame + clause.

D3

a failure of institutional oversight

End focus requires “a failure of institutional oversight” in this model. given frame + identifying clause + new focus.

D4

subject/theme + predicate/new information

Unmarked theme is built as subject/theme + predicate/new information.

D5

fronted frame + clause

Marked theme is built as fronted frame + clause.

Controlled transformation

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

The revised model produced a markedly different result.

subject/theme + predicate/new information. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended unmarked theme effect.

E2

In the final dataset, a different pattern emerged.

fronted frame + clause. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended marked theme effect.

E3

What the inquiry ultimately exposed was a failure of institutional oversight.

given frame + identifying clause + new focus. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended end focus effect.

E4

The revised model produced a markedly different result.

subject/theme + predicate/new information. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended unmarked theme effect.

Communicative production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

The revised model produced a markedly different result. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses subject/theme + predicate/new information accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F2

In the final dataset, a different pattern emerged. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses fronted frame + clause accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F3

What the inquiry ultimately exposed was a failure of institutional oversight. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses given frame + identifying clause + new focus accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____